A Handful of Men: Player's Manual

A tactical stealth game for the Amstrad CPC 6128



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1. Introduction

Norway, winter. A handful of men, each with one special skill, is all it takes to cripple the enemy, one target at a time. You never control an army: you lead two or three commandos through guarded camps, out of sight of sentries, to blow up a radio tower, a fuel depot or a train, and then get every survivor out in the waiting truck.

A Handful of Men is an 8-bit homage to *Commandos: Behind Enemy Lines*, drawn in a cute, chibi style and written for the Amstrad CPC.

2. Getting started

You need an Amstrad CPC 6128, or a CPC 464 or 664 with a 64K memory expansion (128K in total). It also runs in any CPC emulator set to a CPC 6128. On a 64K machine the loader says that 128K is needed and returns to BASIC.

To load: insert the disc `handful_of_men.dsk` and type:

```
RUN"DISC
```

The title menu appears after a few seconds of loading.

3. Controls

The keyboard and a joystick can be used together.

Key	Action
Cursor keys, QAOP or joystick	move the crosshair; push against the edge of the screen to scroll the map
Space, Copy or Fire	select the commando under the crosshair, send the selected commando there, or attack what is under it
Return, Fire 2 or C	crawl / stand up
1, 2, 3	select a commando (the portraits in the panel, left to right)
D	the selected commando's first special ability
G	his second special ability
V	pin the vision cone of the sentry under the crosshair
Esc	give up and go back to the title menu

Moving the crosshair over a sentry also shows his vision cone.

4. The title menu and briefings



The title menu shows the selected mission and a summary of the controls.

- **Choose a mission** with the joystick or the cursor keys (they step through all the missions and the training course), or press **1** to **7** for a mission and **0** for the training course.
- Press **Space** or **Fire** to open the **briefing**: the objective, and what each commando's D and G keys do.
- Press **Space** or **Fire** again to start.

When you accomplish a mission, the menu moves on to the next one.

5. The screen



The top part of the screen is the map. The panel at the bottom shows:

- **The portraits** of your commandos. The selected one is framed in yellow; the bar under each portrait is his health.

- **His name and role**, and whether he is standing, crawling, swimming or in disguise.
- **His kit**: weapons and abilities, with the Sniper's rounds and the Sapper's traps and bombs left.
- **The objective**: what to do next.
- **The alarm**: "ALL QUIET", or the seconds left before enemy reinforcements arrive.

6. Your commandos

Each mission gives you two or three of these five men.

Commando	Attack	D	G
Tiny, Green Beret	knife: silent, close range	drop a radio decoy; press again to make it ping	grab or drop a barrel or a body within reach
Fins, Marine	harpoon: silent, short range	—	—
Duke, Sniper	rifle: long range, needs a clear line of sight, 5 rounds, loud	—	—
Inferno, Sapper	does not fight	lay a bear trap at his feet (2)	plant the time bomb (1)
Spooky, Spy	syringe: silent, close range	put on or take off a German uniform	in uniform, talk to the sentry next to him

- **The Marine swims.** He crosses rivers, canals and the sea, and can't be seen in the water.
- **The bear trap** kills a sentry who walks onto it, silently.
- **The time bomb** goes off 10 seconds after it is planted, with a blast about three tiles across. It always raises the alarm, so plant it and run.
- **In uniform** the Spy is taken for one of the enemy. A sentry he talks to turns to face him and stays put as long as he stays close, which leaves the sentry's back open to your other men.
- **Barrels** explode only when shot, and the blast sets off nearby barrels and destroys whatever is close enough.

To give an order, select a commando (click on him, or press 1, 2 or 3), then click where he should go or what he should attack. Commandos walk around trees, rocks, buildings, fences and water by themselves. A place nobody can reach is ignored.

7. Staying unseen



- **Sentries see in a cone** in front of them. Up close they see anything, even crawling men and bodies. Further away they only notice men standing up. Trees, rocks and buildings block their view.
- **Crawl** to slip past at a distance, but it is slow.
- **Footsteps on snow** can be heard nearby. A sentry who hears them comes to look, with a **?** over his head, for about 10 seconds, then goes back to his patrol. The Green Beret's decoy draws sentries from further away and holds them for about 25 seconds.
- **When a sentry spots you**, a **!** appears over his head. You have about a second and a half to get away or deal with him. After that he opens fire, the siren sounds and every sentry joins in.



- **The alarm** gives you 60 seconds to finish the job and get away before enemy reinforcements arrive. Explosions always raise it.

8. Winning and losing

To win, destroy the mission's target, then get every surviving commando into the truck. Men can climb in early and wait.

You lose if the whole squad is lost, or if the alarm runs out and enemy reinforcements arrive.



The debrief shows whether the target was destroyed and the squad got away, and the **bonus objective**: finishing without ever raising the alarm. It also counts the sentries taken down, the men still alive and the time taken.

9. Training: Boot Camp



New to the game? Press **0** on the title menu. Boot Camp is a gentle course from the south-west corner to the truck, with the Green Beret, the Marine and the Sniper. As your selected commando reaches each lesson, a pink tip replaces the objective in the panel: walking, picking a man, swimming, crawling up behind a sentry and knifing him, watching a patrol's vision cone, the decoy, and the Sniper's shot at the barrel by the training mast. Finish it and the menu moves on to Mission 1.

10. The missions

Mission 1: Baptism of Fire

Squad: Green Beret, Marine, Sniper.

Bring down the radio tower inside the compound. A shot at the barrel right next to its base will do. Then get the squad into the truck at the road junction.

Mission 2: Inferno



Squad: Green Beret, Sapper, Spy.

A fuel depot on a fjord, inside a fenced compound with a single gate on the south road. Plant the time bomb by the fuel tanks, run, then take the truck at the north-west end of the road.

Mission 3: Rough Waters



Squad: Marine, Sniper, Spy.

A U-boat is moored at a wooden pier, with fuel barrels stacked beside it. The dock yard is fenced, with one gate on the east road, but a canal runs down the west edge: the Marine's way in. Shoot the barrels to sink her, then get to the truck south of the gate.

Mission 4: A Bridge Too Far



Squad: Green Beret, Sapper, Sniper.

A railway crosses a river on a steel bridge, with sandbagged posts at both ends. Blow the bridge with the time bomb, then reach the truck in the camp on the north bank. Once the bridge is down, the frozen ford in the west is the only way across.

Mission 5: The Guns of Vardo



Squad: Marine, Sapper, Spy.

A coastal gun in a concrete pit, inside a fenced battery on a headland. The only gate faces the south road, but there is a gap in the north fence that only the Marine can reach, by swimming up the coast. Blow the gun with the time bomb, then take the truck east along the road.

Mission 6: Heavy Water



Squad: Green Beret, Sniper, Spy.

The heavy water plant stands in a fenced compound across a river gorge, reached over a guarded wooden bridge or a frozen stretch further north. The fuel barrels are in a far corner, too far for their blast to reach the plant: the Green Beret must drag one over before the Sniper shoots it. Then get back across the gorge to the truck.

Mission 7: Night Train



Squad: Sniper, Sapper, Spy.

An ammunition train stands in a station yard, fenced to the north and south with a gate in each fence. Blow it up with the time bomb, or give the Sniper a clear shot at the barrel beside the middle wagon. Then leave through the south gate for the truck.

11. Tips

- **Look before you move.** Point at each sentry to see his cone, and learn his patrol before you cross it.
- **Crawl near sentries** and walk only where no one can hear you.
- **Strike from behind.** The knife, harpoon and syringe are silent; the rifle is not.
- **Hide your work.** The Green Beret can drag a body out of sight before another patrol finds it.
- **Use the decoy and the Spy** to turn a sentry away from the path you need.
- **Plan the getaway.** An explosion starts the 60-second alarm, so have the squad close to the truck before you blow the target.